

Seizures — Frequently Asked Questions

What is a seizure?

A seizure is a sudden burst of abnormal electrical activity in the brain. It causes abnormal muscle movement or stiffening and may change awareness. **A seizure is a sign, not a disease** — it tells us some brain cells are misbehaving.

What causes seizures?

- **Outside the brain:** toxins, some drugs, low blood sugar, liver, kidney or other metabolic disease
- **Inside the brain:** tumor, inflammation (meningoencephalitis), stroke, bleeding, trauma or old scar tissue
- **Idiopathic epilepsy:** most likely in otherwise healthy dogs **1–6 years old** — they are born with a lower seizure threshold
- Pets **under 1 year** → birth defects, infection, metabolic disease are more likely. **Older pets** → brain tumor or stroke

How do we find the cause?

A neurological exam and detailed history (to confirm the events are seizures), blood work, **brain MRI** and **spinal fluid analysis**. Finding the cause leads to better control.

Is my flea/tick or heartworm product the cause?

Isoxazoline products (Bravecto, Credelio, NexGard, Simparica) carry an FDA seizure warning, but reactions are rare and usually happen **within 24 hours** of a dose. Heartworm preventives at normal doses are considered safe, even in dogs with the MDR1 mutation.

When do we start medication?

- More than 1 seizure every 6 weeks
 - A seizure lasting **3 minutes or longer**
 - More than 1 seizure in 24 hours (cluster)
 - Slow or severe recovery after a seizure
 - A known progressive cause (tumor, inflammation)
- "Seizures beget seizures" — each seizure makes the next one easier, and untreated seizures can recruit healthy brain cells and become harder to control.

What should I expect?

Seizures are **managed, not cured**. Our goal is **no more than 1 seizure every 6–8 weeks** with acceptable side effects. Most dogs are well controlled on 1–2 medications; about 15–30% remain difficult to control. Doses may be adjusted over weeks to months. After **12 months seizure-free** we may discuss a slow taper. **Australian Shepherds and Border Collies** often have more severe epilepsy and do best with early, aggressive treatment.

Diet and supplements

These complement — never replace — seizure medication.

- **Purina NeuroCare** diet or **MCT oil** (C8/C10 only, e.g., Whole Foods 365 brand). MCT oil: give twice daily with food; start with ½ tsp and increase by ½ tsp every 3 days. If diarrhea occurs, stop until stools are normal for 2 days, then restart at the last well-tolerated dose.
- Home-cooked or ketogenic diets: work with a veterinary nutritionist (BalancelT.com, petdiets.com).
- **CBD oil** is not recommended as a stand-alone treatment and may change seizure-drug blood levels.
- On **potassium bromide**? Avoid salty snacks and make any diet change gradually over 4–6 weeks.

Helping at home

- Keep a **seizure log**: date, time, length, what it looked like and anything unusual that day. Bring it to every visit.
- Keep a **regular sleep schedule** — sleep loss can trigger seizures.
- During a seizure: keep your pet away from stairs and water, keep your hands away from the mouth, and time it.

Go to the ER if:

- A seizure lasts **longer than 5 minutes**
- **More than 3 seizures in a day** (or more than your pet's usual cluster)
- Your pet **does not return to normal** between seizures

Death from seizures is very unlikely, except with prolonged seizures that do not respond to emergency treatment.